

Area of Study 2F – Judaism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Judaism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about the issues of peace and conflict, and crime and punishment.

There are four sections: Jewish Beliefs, Crime and Punishment, Living the Jewish Life and Peace and Conflict.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Jews today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Jew's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Judaism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Judaism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.8)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.4)*

Students should recognise that Judaism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Judaism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Judaism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Judaism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Orthodox, Reform and Liberal traditions.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of the Almighty: how the characteristics of the Almighty are shown in the Torah, and why they are important in Jewish life today, including One, Creator, Law-Giver and Judge, including reference to Genesis 2.
1.2	The nature and importance of Shekhinah: how the divine presence is shown in the Torah and why it is important including interpretations of 2 Chronicles 7:1–3; the divergent understandings of Shekhinah found in different forms of Orthodox Judaism and the importance of them for Jews today.
1.3	The nature and purpose of the Messiah: how messiahship is shown in the scriptures, including Jeremiah 23:5–8; the nature and significance of the Messianic Age and the Jewish responsibility to bring it about; divergent understandings of the Messiah in different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism and the importance of them for Jewish people today.
1.4	The covenant with Abraham and his descendants: the nature and history of the Abrahamic covenant; the role of Abraham in the covenant, including Genesis 17; why the Promised Land covenanted to Abraham and his descendants is important for Jews today.
1.5	The Covenant at Sinai: the nature and history of the Covenant at Sinai (the Ten Commandments), including Exodus 20; the role and significance of Moses in the Covenant at Sinai; divergent understandings of how and why the Decalogue is important in Jewish life today.
1.6	Sanctity of life: why human life is holy for Jewish people; how life is shown as special. The nature and importance of Pikuach Nefesh (primacy of life): life takes precedence over everything, with reference to Talmud Yoma 83–84; divergent understandings of how and why the principle of Pikuach Nefesh is applied by Jews today.
1.7	Moral principles and the Mitzvot: the nature and importance of the Mitzvot, including reference to the Mishneh Torah of Maimonides: Sefer Madda; the importance of the relationship between keeping the Mitzvot and free will; the Mitzvot between humans and the Almighty, and between humans; divergent understandings of the importance of the Mitzvot between the Almighty and humans, and between humans, for Jewish life today.
1.8*	Jewish beliefs about life after death: divergent Jewish understandings of the nature and significance of life after death including reference to different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism; Jewish teachings about life after death including interpretations of Ecclesiastes 12; the nature of resurrection and judgement; why belief in life after death may be important for Jews today.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Jewish attitudes towards justice: the nature of justice and why justice is important for Jews, including Deuteronomy 19:19–21; Jewish responses to why justice is important for the victim; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why justice is important, regardless of religion and belief, and Jewish responses to these attitudes.
2.2	Jewish attitudes towards crime: Jewish teachings about and responses to the nature, causes and problem of crime, including Deuteronomy 11; what action is taken by Jewish individuals and Jewish groups to end the causes of crime, including Jewish Care and the work of synagogues.
2.3	Jewish teachings about good, evil and suffering: Jewish teachings about the nature of good actions and how they are rewarded, including Exodus 33, and teachings about the nature of evil actions and how they are punished; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) about why people suffer, including believing in religion, and Jewish responses to them; divergent Jewish teachings and responses to why people suffer.
2.4	Jewish attitudes towards punishment: the nature of punishment, why punishment is important for Jews, Jewish teachings about punishment, including Leviticus 24:19–23; why punishment can be regarded as justice, why punishment might be needed in society.
2.5	Jewish attitudes towards the aims of punishment: divergent Jewish attitudes towards the use of punishment, the nature and meaning of Jewish teachings about punishment, with reference to Genesis 9:1–6; Jewish teachings on why punishment can be regarded as justice; why punishment might be needed in society.
2.6	Jewish teachings about forgiveness: Jewish teachings and responses to the nature of forgiveness, including Psalm 130 and Isaiah 55:6–8, how offenders are forgiven by the community and why this is needed; Jewish teachings about the nature of restorative justice and why is it important for criminals, including Isaiah 55:6–8.
2.7	Jewish teachings about the treatment of criminals: Jewish teachings about the treatment of criminals; divergent Jewish attitudes towards the use of torture, human rights, fair trial and trial by jury, including reference to Deuteronomy 19:9–21; the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, which may accept use of torture if it is for the greater good.
2.8	Jewish attitudes towards the death penalty: the nature and purpose of capital punishment; divergent Jewish attitudes and teachings for and against capital punishment, including Exodus 21:12–25 and Mishnah Makkot 1:10; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards the use of capital punishment, including the application of ethical theories, such as situation ethics, and Jewish responses to them.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	The nature and purpose of Jewish public acts of worship: the nature, features and purpose of Jewish public worship, including interpretations of Psalms 116:12–19; the nature, features and importance of synagogue services for the Jewish community and the individual.
3.2	The Tenakh and the Talmud: the nature, features, purpose and significance of the Tenakh (the written law) and Talmud (the oral law) for Jews in daily life today with reference to Perkei Avot 2; the nature and purpose of Jewish laws food laws, kashrut, including kosher and treifah and the separation of dairy and meat, including reference to Deuteronomy 14:3–10; the divergent implications of the Jewish food laws for Jews today.
3.3	The nature and purpose of prayer in the home and of private prayer: the nature, features and purpose of prayer three times a day; the importance of having different forms of prayers, including interpretations of Psalms 55:16–23.
3.4*	The nature and importance of the Shema and the Amidah (the standing prayer); when the Shema and the Amidah might be used, how and why, including reference to the Mezuzah; the importance of having the Shema and the Amidah for Jews today, including reference to Deuteronomy 6:4.
3.5	The importance of ritual for Jews today: the nature, features and purpose of birth rituals (including Brit Milah), Bar and Bat Mitzvahs, and marriage rituals, including interpretations of Genesis 21:1–8, Genesis 17 and Leviticus 12; the nature, purpose and importance of the mourning rituals of funeral, shiva, avelut and yahrzeit for Jews today; divergent understandings of the importance of each ritual for different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism today.
3.6	The nature, features, history and purpose of celebrating Shabbat: the nature, features and purpose of the celebration of Shabbat in the home and in the synagogue, including interpretations of Exodus 31:12–18; why the celebration of Shabbat is important for the Jewish community and the individual today.
3.7	Jewish festivals: the nature, history, purpose and significance of Jewish festivals; the origins and meaning of specific festivals, including Rosh Hashanah, Yom Kippur, Pesach, Shavuot and Sukkot, including interpretations of Leviticus 23 (Rosh Hashanah); divergent understandings of why festivals are important to different forms of Orthodox and Reform Judaism today.
3.8	Features of the synagogue: the nature, history and purpose of the different design of the synagogues in Liberal, Reform and Orthodox Judaism, including facing Jerusalem, layout of seating the Ark and the bimah and with reference to Proverbs 14:28; how and why the synagogue is used by the different communities, including reference to Exodus 27:20–21; how and why objects of devotion are used within the synagogues, including a yad, Torah Scroll, ner tamid and menorah.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Jewish attitudes towards peace: divergent teachings about the importance of peace for Jews; Jewish teachings about peace, including Deuteronomy 20:10–12.
4.2	The role of Jews in peacemaking: Jewish teachings about peacemaking; the importance of justice, forgiveness and reconciliation for Jews in peacemaking, including Perkei Avot 1:18; the work of Jews working for peace today, what they do and why they try to work for peace.
4.3	Jewish attitudes to conflict: Jewish teachings and responses to the nature and causes of conflict; Jewish responses to the causes, including Isaiah 2:1–5 and links to situation ethics; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes about the role of religion in the causes of conflict and Jewish responses to them.
4.4	Jewish attitudes to pacifism: Jewish teachings and responses to the nature and history of pacifism; divergent Jewish teachings about passive resistance, including interpretations of Micah 4:1–6 and an example of its use, including Emanuel Ringelblum.
4.5	Jewish attitudes to the Just War theory: Jewish teachings and responses to the nature, history and importance of the Just War theory; the conditions of a Just War, including Milchemet reshut and the implications of Deuteronomy 20; divergent Jewish opinions on whether a Just War is possible, including the application of ethical theories such as situation ethics.
4.6	Jewish attitudes to Holy War: Jewish teachings and responses to the nature of a Holy War; the nature and meaning of Jewish teachings about war and peace, including ideas about Milchemet mitzvah and 2 Samuel 22; divergent Jewish teachings about war; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) attitudes towards Holy War and Jewish responses to them.
4.7	Jewish attitudes to weapons of mass destruction (WMD): Jewish teachings and responses to the problems and benefits of WMD; Jewish attitudes towards the use of such weapons, including the concept of Purity of Arms and interpretations of Deuteronomy 20; non-religious attitudes (including atheist and Humanist) and the application of ethical theories (such as utilitarianism) which support the acquisition of weapons of mass destruction, and Jewish responses to them.
4.8	Jewish attitudes to issues surrounding conflict: Jewish teachings and responses to the nature and history of problems involved in conflict – violence, war and terrorism, including interpretations of Psalm 10:12–18; how Jews have worked to overcome these issues; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) views towards the issues surrounding conflict and Jewish responses to them.